# PIA3142 Global Social Movements — Week 1 Summary: Intro / Organizational Meeting

Course: City University of Hong Kong, Department of Public and International Affairs, Sem A, A.Y. 2026/27.

Week 1 is the introductory and organizational session. Its content is deliberately foundational and does two jobs: it fixes what the object of study actually is (what counts as a "social movement"), and it sets out the questions the rest of the course will try to answer. The five slides divide cleanly along that line — the definitions come first, the questions second. Read the file in order; each section says explicitly how it builds on the one before.

## 1. Framing: what Week 1 sets up

- The title slide presents the course and the week. The background image is a mural of a dense crowd confronting uniformed soldiers, with a woman shielding a child — mass mobilization, state force, and the human stakes of contention. It is the visual statement of the course's subject matter, not study content as such.
- The session is labelled "Intro/Organizational Meeting", so it carries the administrative material (course outline, assessment, readings) alongside the intellectual framing.
- The intellectual framing has two halves, and they are the two halves of the deck:
    - Slides 2–3 ("Social Movements — Some Definitions") answer: what is the thing we are studying?
    - Slides 4–5 ("Key Questions") answer: what are we trying to explain about it?
- Everything later in the semester sits downstream of these two. The definitions supply the vocabulary; the questions supply the research agenda. The theoretical building blocks named at the end (section 6) are the tools that will be used to answer the questions, and they are only named here — not developed.

## 2. Defining the object: three classic definitions of "social movement"

The slide "Social Movements — Some Definitions" does not settle on one definition. It places three definitions side by side, from three different decades and three different traditions. That is the point of the slide: there is no single agreed definition of a social movement, and the differences between the definitions are themselves informative. Each of the three adds a layer the previous one did not have.

### 2.1 The first layer — movements as collective enterprises born of unrest

"Social movements can be viewed as collective enterprises to establish a new order of life. They have their inception in the condition of unrest, and derive their motive power on one hand from dissatisfaction with the current form of life, and on the other hand, from wishes and hopes for a new scheme or system of living" — Blumer 1939.

Unpacking what this definition does:

- "Collective enterprises" — movements are joint, coordinated undertakings, not the acts of isolated individuals. The unit is the collectivity.
- "To establish a new order of life" — movements are oriented to change. They aim at a different arrangement of life, not merely at expressing a grievance or venting emotion.
- "Their inception in the condition of unrest" — movements do not appear from nowhere. They presuppose a background condition of discontent. This is a claim about origins: no unrest, no movement.
- "Motive power" comes from two sources, and this is the definition's most distinctive move — it is a two-motor account of motivation:
    - A negative motor: dissatisfaction with the current form of life.
    - A positive motor: wishes and hopes for a new scheme or system of living.
- Because the definition is written in terms of subjective conditions — dissatisfaction and hope — rather than formal organization, it implies a movement can exist with very little organisational structure. That openness is exactly what the next definition tightens up.

### 2.2 The second layer — movements as collectivities with continuity and informal leadership

"A social movement is a collectivity acting with some continuity to promote or resist a change in the society or organization of which it is a part. As a collectivity a movement is a group with indefinite and shifting membership and with leadership whose position is determined more by informal response of the members than by formal procedures for legitimating authority" — Turner & Killian 1972.

This builds directly on 2.1 and adds three things Blumer's definition left open:

- Continuity. The movement acts "with some continuity" — it persists over time. This is the criterion that separates a social movement from a crowd, a riot, a march, or a one-off protest. Duration is doing real analytical work here.
- Direction is not fixed to "progressive". Movements "promote or resist" change. A movement can be on either side of a change — reactionary and conservative movements are still movements. This is a correction to any instinct to define movements by their politics.
- Organisational form. Membership is "indefinite and shifting" rather than a fixed roster, and leadership rests on "informal response of the members" rather than "formal procedures for legitimating authority". So a movement is a group whose authority is earned by responsiveness, not conferred by rules or elections.

Use this definition when the question is what kind of group a movement is. It is an organisational description where 2.1 was a motivational one.

### 2.3 The third layer — excluded groups and noninstitutional political participation

Social movements are "those organized efforts, on the part of excluded groups, to promote or resist changes in the structure of society that involve recourse to noninstitutional forms of political participation" — McAdam 1982.

This builds on both of the previous definitions and adds a political criterion that neither of them had:

- "Organized efforts" — retains the collectivity/organisation emphasis from 2.1 and 2.2.
- "On the part of excluded groups" — locates movements socially. Movements are the politics of those shut out of normal channels, not the politics of those who already have access.
- "Changes in the structure of society" — the target is not just a policy or a government but the structure itself. Compare this with 2.1's "new order of life": both are ambitious about the depth of change, but McAdam locates it in social structure.
- "Recourse to noninstitutional forms of political participation" — this is the definition's key criterion and the one the course relies on most. It means protest, demonstration, strike, boycott, direct action, occupation: political action taken outside the institutional channels of elections, courts, lobbying, and parties. It is the definition of the field of contentious politics.

### 2.4 Reading the three definitions together

The three are not rival trivia to memorise separately. They are three complementary cuts on the same object, and it is worth being able to say which cut answers which question:

- Blumer 1939 answers where a movement comes from and why anyone bothers: unrest, dissatisfaction, and hope.
- Turner & Killian 1972 answers what kind of thing a movement is: a continuous collectivity with shifting membership and informal leadership, which may promote or resist change.
- McAdam 1982 answers who is doing it and how: excluded groups, using noninstitutional forms of political participation.

Two things to carry forward from the comparison. First, "promote or resist" appears in both 2.2 and 2.3 — the course does not assume movements are on the "right side" of history. Second, the disagreement between the definitions is itself a finding: because the definitions differ, case selection and measurement in this literature are contested, which is why the last line of the lecture's questions slide is a warning about disagreement.

## 3. The distinction the slide insists on: social movement versus social movement organization (SMO)

Note the distinction between “social movement” and “social movement organization.”

The slide ends its definitions section with this instruction, and it is a warning against a specific and common error:

- A social movement is the broad collective project or current — the diffuse, shifting collectivity described in sections 2.1–2.3.
- A social movement organization (SMO) is a formal organisation within or around that current — a named body with a budget, staff, and defined membership.

- One movement typically contains many SMOs, and movements outlive the SMOs that carry them (organisations fold; the movement's demands can persist).
- Why it matters: conflating the two produces bad analysis. It leads to attributing a whole movement's rise or decline to a single organisation, or to studying the organisations and believing you have studied the movement.

This distinction is what makes the next slide coherent: the dimensions there are said to apply to "social movements and SMOs" jointly, because both are objects of study but they are not the same object.

## 4. Four dimensions on which movements and SMOs vary

The slide continues under the same "Some Definitions" heading: social movements and SMOs vary on many different dimensions. "Among them" signals the list is illustrative, not exhaustive. The four dimensions given:

- The causes they promote or espouse, or their goals — ranging from radical re-organisation of society at one end to narrowly defined issues at the other.
- Their spatial or political organisation — local, national, or transnational.
- The nature of the actors, organisations, or institutions on which they make their demands — inter-governmental organisations, non-governmental organisations, national governments, or corporations.
- The methods or tactics they use.

Why this slide earns its place: the course is comparative and case-based, and these four dimensions are the axes along which any two cases get compared. They are the comparison grid. When you are asked to analyse a movement later in the semester, these are the coordinates to fill in. Note also that dimension two (local/national/transnational) is the hook for the course's "global" framing, which returns in question four of section 5.

## 5. The key questions the course sets out to answer

The next slide lists the questions the course covers. They run from the individual decision to participate up to system-level outcomes, so there is a clear progression inside the list itself:

- What does it take for people to rebel against, or participate in social movements pressing demands on, authority? This is the micro-level question: the individual's entry into contention.
- What are the main forces that drive them to get involved? Under what conditions are they likely to do so? How do they become willing to die for others? This pushes the same question to its extreme. Willingness to die for others is the hard case for any account built on self-interest, so it is the point where theories have to explain sacrifice rather than benefit.
- How does mass participation translate into social (sometimes revolutionary) change? What makes a given movement more or less successful? This is the outcome question. Note that "success" is treated as a variable to be explained, not as something assumed.

- How does globalization affect domestic patterns of contentious politics? This is the course's global question, and it connects back to the spatial dimension in section 4 — the local/national/transnational axis.

The slide closes with a caveat: "as it is often the case in the social sciences, there is a lot of disagreement about what the right answers are." Take this seriously as a study instruction — the course presents competing theoretical answers to these questions rather than one settled account, and the definitions in section 2 already demonstrate that disagreement.

## 6. From questions to theory: the announced building blocks and the research project

The final slide takes its text from the syllabus and the course outline, presented as a quotation. It restates the questions in more operational form: When do movements arise? What do the organizers do to mobilize people and motivate them to stay? How do they deal with fence-sitters and movement foes? Why do some movements scale up and become transnational? Why do movements dissipate?

Note how these rephrase section 5: "mobilize people and motivate them to stay" is the recruitment question plus the problem of retention; "fence-sitters and movement foes" is the problem of the uncommitted and the opponent; "scale up and become transnational" is the spatial dimension again; "why do movements dissipate" is the decline side of the outcome question.

The same extract then names the theoretical toolkit the course will use. It describes itself as an overview of the social movements and Contentious Politics literature, and announces the primary theoretical building blocks:

- Political Opportunities — the openings and constraints in the political environment that make collective action viable.
- Resource Mobilization — the organisational, material, and human resources that make collective action possible.
- Framing — the interpretive work that makes a grievance meaningful and motivates participation.

Important for study: the lecture only names these three here. They are announced for later weeks, not defined in Week 1. Mark them as things to be filled in, and expect them to be presented as the competing answers to the questions in section 5 — political opportunities speaks most directly to question two's "under what conditions", resource mobilization to how participation is actually produced, and framing to why people are moved.

The extract also sets out the assessment structure in outline: students investigate movements of their own choice for a research project, and the results are presented to the class. That project is where the four dimensions from section 4 get applied to a specific case.

## 7. How the lecture builds: the review order in one pass

Use this chain to review, and use the numbered sections above to fill in each link:

- The definitions come first because you cannot ask when movements arise until you know what a movement is (section 2).
- The three definitions stack: 2.1 supplies motivation, 2.2 supplies organisational form (continuity, informal leadership, promote or resist), 2.3 supplies the political criterion (excluded groups, noninstitutional participation).
- The social movement / SMO distinction (section 3) is required before the variation slide, because that slide applies to both objects at once.
- The four dimensions of variation (section 4) are the comparison grid, and the fourth question's concern with globalization builds on its spatial dimension.
- The key questions (section 5) move from the individual's decision, to high-risk commitment, to outcomes and success, to globalization — and the syllabus restatement in section 6 rewrites them in operational form.
- The three named building blocks at the end (section 6) are the tools that will answer those questions; they are only named in Week 1.